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FAMILY RESOURCE

In Their Hands

Coins of the New Testament · A guide for families of children PreK–8

WELCOME

Every coin in this exhibition was made, spent and held during the years of the New Testament. Some were in circulation when Jesus was born; one was minted in the very year of his Passion; others passed through the hands of the apostles. This guide will help you talk about the exhibition at home, whether your child visited with their class or you explore it online together.

WHAT IS IN THEIR HANDS?

Eleven coins, three cases

The exhibition follows the New Testament in three display cases. **Case 6, The World of Jesus,** holds the coins of the rulers at his birth. **Case 7, Ministry and Passion,** holds the coins of his teaching and his trial. **Case 8, The Early Church,** holds the coins of the rulers the apostles stood before. Eight of the coins are genuine; three — the Tribute Penny, the Shekel of Tyre and the coin of Herod Antipas — are museum-quality replicas, because originals are exceptionally rare.

CASE 6 · THE WORLD OF JESUS



Augustus Caesar · Luke 2:1



Herod the Great · Matthew 2:13



Aretas IV · Mark 6:17–18

CASE 7 · MINISTRY AND PASSION



The Widow's Mite · Mark 12:41–44



The Tribute Penny · Matthew 22:21



Shekel of Tyre · Matthew 26:15



Pontius Pilate · Matthew 27:24



Herod Antipas · Luke 23:9

CASE 8 · THE EARLY CHURCH



Herod Agrippa I · Acts 12:2–3



Emperor Claudius · Acts 18:2



Porcius Festus · Acts 25:12

AT THE EXHIBITION

Four ways in

- **The display cases** — each coin with its scripture verse, its story and a magnified view of both sides
- **The Gospel Timeline** — the eleven coins in order, from the census at Christ's birth to Paul's appeal to Caesar, each beside the passage it belongs to
- **Hands of History** — *whose hands held this?* Children meet a Roman soldier, a Temple priest, a widow, a merchant, a mother in Bethlehem, Paul of Tarsus and a Nabataean princess
- **Real or Replica?** — five pairs of ancient coins, one genuine and one fake, and the clues experts use to tell them apart
- **Two posters** — *Faith and Reason* and *The Weight of Thirty Pieces*

> MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION
>
> Explore it together online at any time — the coins, the timeline and the games all work on a phone or tablet.
>
> minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/in-their-hands

TALKING WITH YOUR CHILD

Questions to start with

PREK–K

- What did the coins look like? Were they big or tiny?
- Whose picture was on a coin? Whose picture is on ours?
- The widow gave two tiny coins. Why did Jesus say that was the biggest gift?

GRADES 1–2

- Which person in *Hands of History* would you most like to have met?
- Why do you think the coins of King Herod had no faces on them?
- What would you have said if someone tried to trap you with a hard question?

GRADES 3–8

- Which coin surprised you most, and why?
- Pilate's coin was made in the very year of the Passion. What difference does it make to hold something from that year?
- How can you tell a real ancient coin from a fake?
- Jesus said, *give back to Caesar what is Caesar's, and to God what is God's.* What belongs to God?

AT HOME

Simple activities

- **Read a coin.** Empty a purse or a pocket onto the table. Whose face is on each coin? What do the words say? What is each coin claiming? Then read Matthew 22:15–22 together.
- **Two small coins.** Keep a jar for giving. Like the widow, decide together what you can give that truly costs something — not only money, but time or a favorite thing.
- **Coin rubbings.** Lay paper over a coin and rub gently with the side of a crayon. Ancient coins were struck by hand, one at a time — look at how even modern coins differ.
- **Whose hands held this?** Choose any old coin and invent its journey. Who has held it? Where has it been? Children who visited can borrow the idea from *Hands of History.*
- **Coin detective.** With a magnifying glass, look for wear on the highest points of a coin. Real age wears a coin evenly — one of the clues from *Real or Replica?*

READ TOGETHER

The stories behind the coins

- **PreK–2:** the birth of Jesus and the census (Luke 2:1–7); the widow's offering (Mark 12:41–44)
- **Grades 3–5:** the flight into Egypt (Matthew 2:13–15); the question about the tax (Matthew 22:15–22); thirty pieces of silver (Matthew 26:14–16)
- **Grades 6–8:** Jesus before Herod Antipas (Luke 23:6–12); Peter freed from prison (Acts 12:1–11); Paul appeals to Caesar (Acts 25:6–12)

FAITH AND HISTORY

Evidence you can hold

For many years some scholars doubted that Pontius Pilate was a real person. In 1961 a stone carved with his name and title was found at Caesarea Maritima — but Pilate's coins, like the one in Case 7, had been evidence all along. The death of Herod Agrippa I in Acts 12 is also described by the Jewish historian Josephus, and Claudius' order expelling Jews from Rome in Acts 18 is confirmed by the Roman historian Suetonius. The coins help children see that the Gospels happened in a real place, among real rulers, in real years.

ABOUT THE MINI MUSEUM

The Mini Museum brings curated exhibitions of real artifacts, specimens and primary sources into schools, with lesson plans and a digital companion at minimuseumproject.org.